

‘Oh!’ said Bundle, rather damped.

‘And what can I do for you?’ inquired the Superintendent.

Bundle came straight to the point.

‘I’ve always heard that you people at Scotland Yard have lists of all secret societies and things like that that are formed in London.’

‘We try to keep up to date,’ said Superintendent Battle cautiously.

‘I suppose a great many of them aren’t really dangerous.’

‘We’ve got a very good rule to go by,’ said Battle. ‘The more they talk, the less they’ll do. You’d be surprised how well that works out.’

‘And I’ve heard that very often you let them go on?’

Battle nodded.

‘That’s so. Why shouldn’t a man call himself a Brother of Liberty and meet twice a week in a cellar and talk about rivers of blood—it won’t hurt either him or us. And if there is trouble any time, we know where to lay our hands on him.’

‘But sometimes, I suppose,’ said Bundle slowly, ‘a society may be more dangerous than anyone imagines?’

‘Very unlikely,’ said Battle.

‘But it *might* happen,’ persisted Bundle.

‘Oh! it *might*,’ admitted the Superintendent.

There was a moment or two’s silence. Then Bundle said quietly.

‘Superintendent Battle, could you give me a list of secret societies that have their headquarters in Seven Dials?’

It was Superintendent Battle’s boast that he had never been seen to display emotion. But Bundle could have sworn that just for a moment his eyelids flickered and he looked taken aback. Only for a moment, however. He was his usual wooden self as he said:

‘Strictly speaking, Lady Eileen, there’s no such place as Seven Dials nowadays.’

‘No?’

‘No. Most of it is pulled down and rebuilt. It was rather a low quarter once, but it’s very respectable and high class nowadays. Not at all a romantic spot to poke about in for mysterious secret societies.’

‘Oh!’ said Bundle, rather nonplussed.

‘But all the same I should very much like to know what put that neighbor-hood into your head, Lady Eileen?’

‘Have I got to tell you?’

‘Well, it saves trouble, doesn’t it? We know where we are, so to speak?’

Bundle hesitated for a minute.

‘There was a man shot yesterday,’ she said slowly. ‘I thought I had run over him—’

‘Mr Ronald Devereux?’

‘You know about it, of course. Why has there been nothing in the papers?’

‘Do you really want to know that, Lady Eileen?’

‘Yes, please.’

‘Well, we just thought we should like to have a clear twenty-four hours—see? It will be in the papers to-morrow.’

‘Oh!’ Bundle studied him, puzzled.

What was hidden behind that immovable face. Did he regard the shooting of Ronald Devereux as an ordinary crime or as an extraordinary one.

‘He mentioned Seven Dials when he was dying,’ said Bundle slowly.

‘Thank you,’ said Battle. ‘I’ll make a note of that.’

He wrote a few words on the blotting pad in front of him.

Bundle started on another tack.

‘Mr Lomax, I understand, came to see you yesterday about a threatening letter he had had.’

‘He did.’

‘And that was written from Seven Dials?’

‘It had Seven Dials written at the top of it, I believe.’

Bundle felt as though she was battering hopelessly on a locked door.

‘If you’ll let me advise you, Lady Eileen—’

‘I know what you’re going to say.’

‘I should go home and—well, think no more about these matters.’

‘Leave it to you, in fact?’

‘Well,’ said Superintendent Battle, ‘after all, we *are* the professionals.’

‘And I’m only an amateur? Yes, but you forget one thing—I mayn’t have your knowledge and skill—but I have one advantage over you. I can work in the dark.’

She thought that the Superintendent seemed a little taken aback, as though the force of her words struck home.

‘Of course,’ said Bundle, ‘if you won’t give me a list of secret societies—’

‘Oh! I never said that. You shall have a list of the whole lot.’

He went to the door, put his head through and called out something, then came back to his chair. Bundle, rather unreasonably, felt baffled. The ease with which he acceded to her request seemed to her suspicious. He was looking at her now in a placid fashion.

‘Do you remember the death of Mr Gerald Wade?’ she asked abruptly.

‘Down at your place, wasn’t it? Took an overdraught of sleeping mixture.’

‘His sister says he never took things to make him sleep.’

‘Ah!’ said the Superintendent. ‘You’d be surprised what a lot of things there are that sisters don’t know.’

Bundle again felt baffled. She sat in silence till a man came in with a typewritten sheet of paper, which he handed to the Superintendent.

‘Here you are,’ said the latter when the other had left the room. ‘The Blood Brothers of St Sebastian. The Wolf Hounds. The Comrades of Peace. The Comrades Club. The Friends of Oppression. The Children of Moscow. The Red Standard Bearers. The Herrings. The Comrades of the Fallen—and half a dozen more.’

He handed it to her with a distinct twinkle in his eye.

‘You give it to me,’ said Bundle, ‘because you know it’s not going to be the slightest use to me. Do you want me to leave the whole thing alone?’

‘I should prefer it,’ said Bartle. ‘You see—if you go messing round all these places—well, it’s going to give us a lot of trouble.’

‘Looking after me, you mean?’

‘Looking after you, Lady Eileen.’

Bundle had risen to her feet. Now she stood undecided. So far the honours lay with Superintendent Bartle. Then she remembered one slight incident, and she based a last appeal upon it.

‘I said just now that an amateur could do some things which a professional couldn’t. You didn’t contradict me. That’s because you’re an honest man, Superintendent Bartle. You knew I was right.’

‘Go on,’ said Bartle quietly.

‘At Chimneys you let me help. Won’t you let me help now?’

Bartle seemed to be turning the thing over in his mind. Emboldened by his silence, Bundle continued.

Chapter X

Bundle Visits Scotland Yard

NOW it may be said at once that in the foregoing conversation each one of the three participants had, as it were, held something in reserve. That ‘Nobody tells everything’ is a very true motto.

It may be questioned, for instance, if Loraine Wade was perfectly sincere in her account of the motives which had led her to seek out Jimmy Thesiger.

In the same way, Jimmy Thesiger himself had various ideas and plans connected with the forthcoming party at George Lomax’s which he had no intention of revealing to—say, Bundle.

And Bundle herself had a fully-fledged plan which she proposed to put into immediate execution and which she had said nothing whatever about.

On leaving Jimmy Thesiger’s rooms, she drove to Scotland Yard, where she asked to see Superintendent Bartle.

Superintendent Bartle was rather a big man. He worked almost entirely on cases of a delicate political nature. On such a case he had come to Chimneys four years ago, and Bundle was frankly trading on his remembering this fact.

After a short delay, she was taken along several corridors and into the Superintendent’s private room. Bartle was a stolid-looking man with a wooden face. He looked supremely unintelligent and more like a commissioner than a detective.

He was standing by the window when she entered, gazing in an expressionless manner at some sparrows.

‘Good-afternoon, Lady Eileen,’ he said. ‘Sit down, won’t you?’

‘Thank you,’ said Bundle. ‘I was afraid you mightn’t remember me.’ ‘Always remember people,’ said Bartle. He added: ‘Got to in my job.’

'You know pretty well what I'm like, Superintendent Bartle. I butt into things. I'm a Nosey Parker. I don't want to get in your way or to try and do things that you're doing and can do a great deal better. But if there's a chance for an amateur, let me have it.'

Again there was a pause, and then Superintendent Bartle said quietly:

'You couldn't have spoken fairer than you have done, Lady Eileen. But I'm just going to say this to you. What you propose is dangerous. And when I say dangerous, I *mean* dangerous.'

'I've grasped that,' said Bundle. 'I'm not a fool.'

'No,' said Superintendent Bartle. 'Never knew a young lady who was less so. What I'll do for you, Lady Eileen, is this. I'll just give you one little hint. And I'm doing it because I never have thought much of the motto 'Safety First.' In my opinion half the people who spend their lives avoiding being run over by buses had much better be run over and put safely out of the way. They're no good.'

This remarkable utterance issuing from the conventional lips of Superintendent Bartle quite took Bundle's breath away.

'What was the hint you were going to give me,' she asked at last.

'You know Mr Eversleigh, don't you?'

'Know Bill? Why, of course. But what—'

'I think Mr Bill Eversleigh will be able to tell you all you want to know about Seven Dials.'

'Bill knows about it? *Bill*?'

'I didn't say that. Not at all. But I think, being a quick-witted young lady, you'll get what you want from him.'

And now,' said Superintendent Bartle firmly, 'I'm not going to say another word.'

'Look here,' he said. 'Lorraine must keep out of this, musn't she?'

'I certainly think she'd better.'

'Next time,' said Jimmy kindly.

'And suppose there isn't a next time,' said Lorraine.

'Oh! there probably will be. Not a doubt of it.'

'I see. I'm just to go home and—wait.'

'That's it,' said Jimmy, with every appearance of relief. 'I thought you'd understand.'

'You see,' explained Bundle, 'three of us forcing our way in might look rather suspicious. And you would be particularly difficult. You do see that, don't you?'

'Oh! yes,' said Lorraine.

'Then it's settled—you do nothing,' said Jimmy.

'I do nothing,' said Lorraine meekly.

Bundle looked at her in sudden suspicion. The tameness with which Lorraine was taking it seemed hardly natural. Lorraine looked at her. Her eyes were blue and guileless. They met Bundle's without a quiver even of the lashes. Bundle was only partly satisfied. She found the meekness of Lorraine Wade highly suspicious.

Gerry Wade was the real thing. Our secret service is supposed to be the best in the world. I think Gerry Wade was pretty high up in that service. And that explains everything! I remember saying idly that last evening at Chimneys that Gerry couldn't be quite such an ass as he made himself out to be.'

'And if you're right?' said Bundle, practical as ever.

'Then the thing's bigger than we thought. This Seven Dials business isn't merely criminal—it's international. One thing's certain, somebody has got to be at this house-party of Lomax's.'

Bundle made a slight grimace.

'I know George well—but he doesn't like me. He'd never think of asking me to a serious gathering. All the same, I might—'

She remained a moment lost in thought.

'Do you think I could work it through Bill?' asked Jimmy. 'He's bound to be there as Codders's right-hand man. He might bring me along somehow or other.'

'I don't see why not,' said Bundle. 'You'll have to prime Bill and make him say the right things. He's incapable of thinking of them for himself.'

'What do you suggest?' asked Jimmy humbly.

'Oh! it's quite easy. Bill describes you as a rich young man—interested in politics, anxious to stand for Parliament. George will fall at once. You know what these political parties are: always looking for new, rich young men. The richer Bill says you are, the easier it will be to manage.'

'Short of being described as Rothschild, I don't mind,' said Jimmy.

'Then I think that's practically settled. I'm dining with Bill to-morrow night, and I'll get a list of who is to be there. That will be useful.'

'I'm sorry you can't be there,' said Jimmy. 'But on the whole I think it's all for the best.'

'I'm not so sure I shan't be there,' said Bundle. 'Codders hates me like poison—but there are other ways.'

She became meditative.

'And what about me?' asked Lorraine in a small, meek voice.

'You're not on in this act,' said Jimmy instantly. 'See? After all, we've got to have someone outside to—er—'

'To what?' said Lorraine.

Jimmy decided not to pursue this tack. He appealed to Bundle.

Chapter XI

Dinner with Bill

BUNDLE set out to keep her appointment with Bill on the following evening full of expectation.

Bill greeted her with every sign of elation.

'Bill really *is* rather nice,' thought Bundle to herself. 'Just like a large, clumsy dog that wags its tail when it's pleased to see you.'

The large dog was uttering short staccato yelps of comment and information.

'You look tremendously fit, Bundle. I can't tell you how pleased I am to see you. I've ordered oysters—you do like oysters, don't you? And how's everything? What did you want to go mouldering about abroad so long? Were you having a very gay time?'

'No, deadily,' said Bundle. 'Perfectly foul. Old diseased colonels creeping about in the sun, and active, wizened spinsters running libraries and churches.'

'Give me England,' said Bill. 'I bar this foreign business—except Switzerland. Switzerland's all right. I'm thinking of going this Christmas. Why don't you come along?'

'I'll think of it,' said Bundle. 'What have you been doing with yourself lately, Bill?'

It was an incautious query. Bundle had merely made it out of politeness and as a preliminary to introducing her own topics of conversation. It was, however, the opening for which Bill had been waiting.

'That's just what I've been wanting to tell you about. You're brainy, Bundle, and I want your advice. You know that musical show, 'Damn Your Eyes?''

'Yes.'

'Well, I'm going to tell you about one of the dirtiest pieces of work imaginable. My God! the theatrical crowd. There's a girl—a Yankee girl—a perfect stunner—'

Bundle's heart sank. The grievances of Bill's lady friends were always interminable—they went on and on and there was no stemming them.

'This girl, Babe St Maur her name is—'

'I wonder how she got that name?' said Bundle sarcastically.

Bill replied literally.

'She got it out of *Who's Who*. Opened it and jabbed her finger down on a page without looking. Pretty nifty, eh? Her real name's Goldschmidt or Abrameier—something quite impossible.'

'Oh! quite,' agreed Bundle.

'Well, Babe St Maur is pretty smart. And she's got muscles. She was one of the eight girls who made the living bridge—'

'Bill,' said Bundle desperately, 'I went to see Jimmy Thesiger yesterday morning.'

'Good old Jimmy,' said Bill. 'Well, as I was telling you, Babe's pretty smart. You've got to be nowadays. She can put it over on most theatrical people. If you want to live, be high-handed, that's what Babe says. And mind you, she's the goods all right. She can act—it's marvellous how that girl can act. She'd not much chance in 'Damn Your Eyes'—just swamped in a pack of good-looking girls. I said why not try the legitimate stage—you know, Mrs Tanqueray—that sort of stuff—but Babe just laughed—'

'Have you seen Jimmy at all?'

'Saw him this morning. Let me see, where was I? Oh, yes, I hadn't got to the rumpus yet. And mind you it was jealousy—sheer, spiteful jealousy. The other girl wasn't a patch on Babe for looks and she knew it. So she went behind her back—'

Bundle resigned herself to the inevitable and heard the whole story of the unfortunate circumstances which had led up to Babe St Maur's summary disappearance from the cast of 'Damn Your Eyes.' It took a long time. When Bill finally paused for breath and sympathy, Bundle said:

'You're quite right, Bill, it's a rotten shame. There must be a lot of jealousy about—'

'The whole theatrical world's rotten with it.'

Suddenly Bundle let out a whoop and both the others started violently. 'Idiot,' said Bundle. 'Imbecile. Me, I mean. I knew there was something I'd forgotten.'

'What?'

'You know Codders—George Lomax, I mean?'

'I've heard of him a good deal,' said Jimmy. 'From Bill and Ronny, you know.'

'Well, Codders is giving some sort of a dry party next week—and he's had a warning letter from Seven Dials.'

'What?' cried Jimmy excitedly, leaning forward. 'You can't mean it?'

'Yes, I do. He told Father about it. Now what do you think that points to?' Jimmy leant back in his chair. He thought rapidly and carefully. At last he spoke. His speech was brief and to the point.

'Something's going to happen at that party,' he said.

'That's what I think,' said Bundle.

'It all fits in,' said Jimmy almost dreamily.

He turned to Loraine.

'How old were you when the war was on?' he asked unexpectedly.

'Nine—no, eight.'

'And Gerry, I suppose, was about twenty. Most lads of twenty fought in the war. Gerry didn't.'

'No,' said Loraine, after thinking a minute or two. 'No, Gerry wasn't a soldier. I don't know why.'

'I can tell you why,' said Jimmy. 'Or at least I can make a very shrewd guess. He was out of England from 1915 to 1918. I've taken the trouble to find that out. And nobody seems to know exactly where he was. I think he was in Germany.'

The colour rose in Loraine's cheeks. She looked at Jimmy with admiration.

'How clever of you.'

'He spoke German well, didn't he?'

'Oh! yes, like a native.'

'I'm sure I'm right. Listen, you two. Gerry Wade was at the Foreign Office. He appeared to be the same sort of amiable idiot—excuse the term, but you know what I mean—as Bill Eversleigh and Ronny Devereux. A purely ornamental excrescence. But in reality he was something quite different. I think

'I think we can say we're sure of certain facts. There's a secret society, with points of resemblance to the Mafia, in existence. Gerry Wade came to know about it. At first he treated it as rather a joke—as an absurdity, shall we say. He couldn't believe in its being really dangerous. But later something happened to convince him, and then he got the wind up in earnest. I rather fancy he must have said something to Ronny Devereux about it. Anyway, when he was put out of the way, Ronny suspected, and he must have known enough to get on the same track himself. The unfortunate thing is that we've got to start quite from the outer darkness. We haven't got the knowledge the other two had.'

'Perhaps that's an advantage,' said Lorraine coolly. 'They won't suspect us and therefore they won't be trying to put us out of the way.'

'I wish I felt sure about that,' said Jimmy in a worried voice. 'You know, Lorraine, old Gerry himself wanted you to keep out of it. Don't you think you could—'

'No, I couldn't,' said Lorraine. 'Don't let's start discussing that again. It's only a waste of time.'

At the mention of the word time, Jimmy's eyes rose to the clock and he uttered an exclamation of astonishment. He rose and opened the door.

'Stevens.'

'Yes, sir?'

'What about a spot of lunch, Stevens? Could it be managed?'

'I anticipated that it would be required, sir. Mrs Stevens has made preparations accordingly.'

'That's a wonderful man,' said Jimmy, as he returned, heaving a sigh of relief. 'Brain, you know. Sheer brain. He takes correspondence courses. I sometimes wonder if they'd do any good to me.'

'Don't be silly,' said Lorraine.

Stevens opened the door and proceeded to bring in a most recherché meal. An omelette was followed by quails and the very lightest things in soufflés.

'Why are men so happy when they're single,' said Lorraine tragically. 'Why are they so much better looked after by other people than by us?'

'Oh! but that's rot, you know,' said Jimmy. 'I mean, they're not. How could they be. I often think—'

He stammered and stopped. Lorraine blushed again.

'It must be. Did Jimmy say anything to you about coming down to the Abbey next week?'

For the first time, Bill gave his attention to what Bundle was saying.

'He was full of a long rigmarole he wanted me to stuff Codders with. About wanting to stand in the Conservative interest. But you know, Bundle, it's too damned risky.'

'Stuff,' said Bundle. 'If George *does* find him out, he won't blame you. You'll just have been taken in, that's all.'

'That's not it at all,' said Bill. 'I mean it's too damned risky for Jimmy. Before he knows where he is, he'll be parked down somewhere like Tooting West, pledged to kiss babies and make speeches. You don't know how thorough Codders is and how frightfully energetic.'

'Well, we'll have to risk that,' said Bundle. 'Jimmy can take care of himself all right.'

'You don't know Codders,' repeated Bill.

'Who's coming to this party, Bill? Is it anything very special?'

'Only the usual sort of muck. Mrs Macarra for one.'

'The M.P.?'

'Yes, you know, always going off the deep end about Welfare and Pure Milk and Save the Children. Think of poor Jimmy being talked to by her.'

'Never mind Jimmy. Go on telling me.'

'Then there's a Hungarian, what they call a Young Hungarian. Countess something unpronounceable. She's all right.'

He swallowed as though embarrassed and Bundle observed that he was crumbling his bread nervously.

'Young and beautiful?' she inquired delicately.

'Oh! rather.'

'I didn't know George went in for female beauty much.'

'Oh! he doesn't. She runs baby feeding in Buda Pesth—something like that. Naturally she and Mrs Macarra want to get together.'

'Who else?'

'Sir Stanley Digby—'

'The Air Minister?'

'Yes. And his secretary, Terence O'Rourke. He's rather a lad, by the way—used to be in his flying days. Then there's a perfectly poisonous German

chap called Herr Eberhard. I don't know who he is, but we're all making the hell of a fuss about him. I've been twice told off to take him out to lunch, and I can tell you, Bundle, it was no joke. He's not like the Embassy chaps, who are all very decent. This man sucks in soup and eats peas with a knife. Not only that, but the brute is always biting his finger-nails—positively gnaws at them.'

'Pretty foul.'

'Isn't it? I believe he invents things—something of the kind. Well, that's all.

Oh! yes, Sir Oswald Coote.'

'And Lady Coote?'

'Yes, I believe she's coming too.'

Bundle sat lost in thought for some minutes. Bill's list was suggestive, but she hadn't time to think out various possibilities just now. She must get on to the next point.

'Bill?' she said. 'What's all this about Seven Dials?'

Bill at once looked horribly embarrassed. He blinked and avoided her glance.

'I don't know what you mean,' he said.

'Nonsense,' said Bundle. 'I was told you know all about it.'

'About what?'

'This was rather a poser. Bundle shifted her ground.

'I don't see what you want to be so secretive for,' she complained.

'Nothing to be secretive about. Nobody goes there much now. It was only a craze.'

This sounded puzzling.

'One gets so out of things when one is away,' said Bundle in a sad voice.

'Oh! you haven't missed much,' said Bill. 'Everyone went there just to say they had been. It was boring really, and, my God, you *can* get tired of fried fish.'

'Where did everyone go?'

'To the Seven Dials Club, of course,' said Bill, staring. 'Wasn't that what you were asking about?'

'I didn't know it by that name,' said Bundle.

'Used to be a slummy sort of district round about Tottenham Court Road way. It's all pulled down and cleaned up now. But the Seven Dials Club keeps

'A clock thrown out of the window,' said Jimmy, staring. It was the first he had heard of it.

'I can't see how it can have anything to do with it,' said Bundle. 'But it's odd somehow. There seems no sense in it.'

'I remember,' said Jimmy slowly. 'I went in to—to see poor old Gerry, and there were the clocks ranged along the mantelpiece. I remember noticing there were only seven—not eight.'

He gave a sudden shiver and explained himself apologetically.

'Sorry. But somehow those clocks have always given me the shivers. I dream of them sometimes. I'd hate to go into that room in the dark and see them there in a row.'

'You wouldn't be able to see them if it was dark,' said Bundle practically. 'Not unless they had luminous dials—Oh!' She gave a sudden gasp and the colour rushed into her cheeks. 'Don't you see? *Seven Dials!*'

The others looked at her doubtfully, but she insisted with increasing vehemence.

'It must be. It can't be a coincidence.'

There was a pause.

'You may be right,' said Jimmy Theisger at last. 'It's—it's dashed odd.'

Bundle started questioning him eagerly.

'Who bought the clocks?'

'All of us.'

'Who thought of them?'

'All of us.'

'Nonsense, somebody must have thought of them first.'

'It didn't happen that way. We were discussing what we could do to get Gerry up, and Pongo said an alarm clock, and somebody said one would be no good, and somebody else—Bill Eversleigh, I think—said why not get a dozen. And we all said good egg and hoofed off to get them. We got one each and an extra one for Pongo and one for Lady Coote—just out of the generosity of our hearts. There was nothing premeditated about it—it just happened.'

Bundle was silenced, but not convinced.

Jimmy proceeded to sum up methodically.